

(FROM LEFT) PAWAR,
SONIA, KARUNANIDHI
AND MAMATA



none. In Tamil Nadu, it fared better with two victories, and the DMK winning the other three. Glibly explaining the losses, the party leadership is in no mood to tone down its attitude towards its allies—present or former. Lalu Prasad Yadav who called on 10, Janpath, offering an alliance for the approaching by-elections in Bihar was politely rebuffed. “Even if the Congress does not win, we will begin rebuilding the organisation in the state which will not happen if we go in for a coalition,” explains Jagdish Tytler, in-charge of the state.

That is the current coalition dharma of the Congress. While Lalu

can be done away with, the NCP will be bullied to accept lesser seats. A stronger ally like Mamata Banerjee will be tolerated, at least till the West Bengal polls in 2011 where the party needs the fiery Trinamool leader to take on the Left. Banerjee has already successfully stalled the UPA's prized Land Acquisition Amendment and Resettlement and Rehabilitation Bills. During the two West Bengal by-elections last month, she persuaded the Congress to give up two of its seats and went on to win both.

For Maharashtra Assembly elections, the Congress is also citing delimitation to bolster its demand for

more seats than the 166 (of 288) it contested in 2004. “If they try and fine-tune it too much, it could be a problem,” warned a NCP leader. The NCP has Mulayam Singh Yadav as its case study. Mulayam is now ruining the day he bailed out the Congress on the nuclear deal.

There is southern discomfort with the Congress too with Tamil Nadu high on Rahul Gandhi's revival list. The DMK has been closely monitoring his meeting with Vijay, a Tamil actor popular with the youth. There are talks of the Congress planning to build an alternative front minus the Dravidian parties by roping in actor-politician Vijaykanth's Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) party. That Karunanidhi recently played host to both Yeddyurappa and Venkaiah Naidu who accompanied him has not gone down too well with the Congress which claims that its state leaders were ignored at the expense of the BJP leaders.

The big brotherly attitude does not include coalition niceties of sharing the fruits of power such as gubernatorial assignments with the allies. In fact, this time round the UPA does not even have the pretence of a common minimum programme in place. Now with its plans to revive the National Advisory Council (NAC), the chasm between the allies and the Congress will only widen. During the last round of the UPA, the NAC had worked as a parallel government and it got more credit than the allies. No matter how much the Left and the RJD claimed ownership of the rural employment programme, National Rural Employment Guarantee Act, it was the NAC that walked away with the accolades. Congress strategists claim that their plan is to ensure that the Congress gets a majority of its own in the next Lok Sabha elections. And for that it needs to be less dependent on its allies. While it needs the allies to prop up this Government, it also needs to build its own organisation to take on the same allies in the future. And therein lies the coalition dilemma of the Congress.

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towards its allies despite a poor show in the bypolls.